Risk Notice
Unknown Level

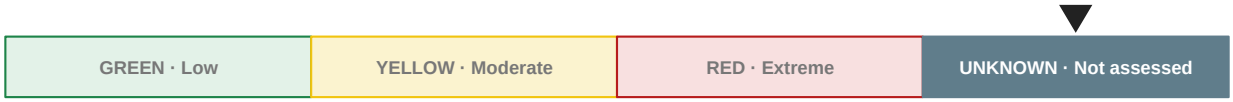
Risk not determined: site offline or lacking concrete information

Risk notice · British English
November 2026

RISK LEVEL

UNKNOWN

Unknown risk: the site is offline or there is no concrete information with which to assess it. Unknown does not mean safe: do not access without prior assessment.



1. Notice Details

Fill in the fields when issuing the notice for an assessed site.

Field	Entry
Notice code	_____
Site name	_____
Category	_____
.onion address	Record only if confirmed by an official source
Reason for classification	[ ] Offline [ ] No concrete information
Checks carried out	No.: _____ Dates: _____
Date of assessment	____ / ____ / _____
Assessed by	_____
Next review	____ / ____ / _____
Level assigned	UNKNOWN · Risk not determined

2. Meaning of the Unknown Level

The unknown level is assigned when **the risk of a site cannot be determined**. It is not an intermediate grade between green and red: it indicates **an absence of assessment**, not an absence of danger.

- There is no basis for calling the site either safe or dangerous.
- **Unknown does not mean safe.** If in doubt, the site should be treated as potentially dangerous.
- The main rule is: **no information, no access**.
- It is a provisional level: the aim is to reclassify the site as green, yellow or red as soon as evidence is available.

3. Reasons for the Unknown Level

Reason A: the site is offline

- Temporary unavailability, owing to slowness or instability of the Tor network or the server.
- Permanent closure of the service, a change of address or a move to another one.
- Taken down by the operator's decision, because of a technical problem or by action of the authorities.
- **Warning:** an address that comes back online may be under a new operator or be a fake copy. Do not assume it is the same site.

Reason B: no concrete information

- Operator not identified and with no presence that can be confirmed on the Surface Web.
- No official or reliable source confirms the address.
- Information found only in anonymous lists, rumours or messages of unknown origin.
- Few, old or contradictory reports about the site.
- No track record from which to judge its stability.

When it applies: use the unknown level if one of the reasons above is present **and** there is no clear sign of danger. If there are indicators of danger, apply the red level. If there is sufficient evidence of safety, apply green or yellow.

4. Risks

- **False sense of security**: mistaking a lack of information for a lack of danger.
- **Traps and clones**: sites of unknown origin may be scams, fake copies or traps (honeypots).
- **Unexpected return**: a site that comes back online may have a new operator, content or behaviour.
- **Malware and scams**: without an assessment, malicious downloads or requests cannot be ruled out.
- **Unlawful or disturbing content** met without warning.
- **Legal risks**: interacting with unlawful content, even unintentionally.
- **Improper recording**: keeping or recommending addresses without a reliable basis.

5. How to Protect Yourself

Risk	Prevention
False sense of security	Never treat unknown as green; apply the rule "no information, no access".
Traps and clones	Do not access addresses received through messages, forums or anonymous lists; always confirm with an official source.
Unexpected return	When the site comes back online, reassess from scratch (operator, address and content) before reclassifying.
Malware and scams	If access is unavoidable, follow the yellow-level precautions: no downloads and no personal data.

Risk	Prevention
Unlawful content	Leave immediately, do not save or share, and report where appropriate.
Legal risks	Know the local law and do not interact with anything unlawful.
Improper recording	Record the address only if it is confirmed by an official source; otherwise record only the name and the reason.

6. Recommended Procedure

1. **Do not access** the site until there is a minimum of information.
2. Record the **reason** (offline, no concrete information, or both) and the **date**.
3. Gather information **without accessing the site**, through the Surface Web: the organisation's official site, the press, security researchers and reports from trusted communities.
4. If the address is confirmed by an official source and the site is offline, run further availability checks, preferably once a week and on different days, with the yellow-level precautions.
5. If the site comes back online, do not assume it is the same one: reassess the operator, the address and the content before any reclassification.
6. Reclassify according to the table below.

Situation found	Level to assign
There are indicators of danger (scam, malware, illegal content)	RED
Operator identified, address confirmed by an official source and stable operation	GREEN
Partial evidence, with no clear sign of danger	YELLOW
Still offline or without concrete information	Remains UNKNOWN

7. If You Accessed It by Mistake or by Necessity

1. Close the tab immediately and use **New Identity**.
2. Do not download or open files. If something was downloaded, do not run it, disconnect the device from the network and run an antivirus scan.
3. If you gave a password or personal data, change your passwords from a secure device and turn on two-step verification.
4. If you come across illegal content or content involving the exploitation of people, leave, do not save or share it, and report it to the competent authorities.
5. Tell the person responsible for the repository and reassess the site, considering the yellow or red level depending on what was found.

8. Validity and Review

Review the record **at least every 30 days**. As a suggestion, sites that stay offline for more than 90 days can be marked **inactive**, keeping the unknown level and the history. Do not delete them from the record, as they may return. Never upgrade a site straight to green without verifiable evidence.

9. Legal Notice

This notice is informative and does not guarantee safety. Using Tor is lawful in most countries, but everyone must know and comply with the law where they are. This document does not list or recommend specific sites.